

Promises and Pressure: The Decision

承诺与压力：决定

Theme: 友谊、家庭与人际关系 · New: 45 · Review: 18 · Planned cumulative progress: 45/6, 127

English Story

The decision was taken **around** a **warm** table in the family house. His **mom** invited both families, and the **debate** that followed was, in her words, a lot of **fun** and very **tense**. “He will tell you what happened,” she said. “I will **say** only this: the **marital** contract is not the marriage.”

The **beginning** of the meeting was formal. A **motion** was proposed, a **request** for a **triple enhancement** of the **schedule**, and a **nod** from the head of the table. “**Apply** for the money,” the **fatherly** uncle said. “**Beg** if you must, but do not **borrow**.” “Do not **panic**,” the **motherly** aunt added. “The **concern** of the woman who raised the child has been received, and at home it is great.”

There was a **demonstrative** moment: the **beloved** grandmother borrowed a pen, signed the paper, and put it down with a slap that disposed of three months of **spite** in one second. “The **scent** of a new plan is better than the **curse** of an old quarrel,” she said, and the **talkative** cousin, for once, said nothing at all.

The **divorce** of the two projects had begun quietly. One would continue; the other would be transmitted to a **replacement** who could give it more time. “I know,” Lin said. “I **like** the little one better.” A **steep** fall in his own hours had taught him that, and the plunging temperature outside made the kitchen feel **like** a **harbor**.

The **wonder** was that the decision had been reached without anyone raising a voice. The **steamy** windows, the **warm** plates, the little indications that people were still there: everything indicated a family that had decided something. “Something has to **commence**,” the cousin finally said. “Call it a **fancy** name if you **like**; the people are the same people.” Some of it was **luck**, and some of it was the part nobody had planned: the cousin's silence, the aunt's arithmetic, the way a family decides without deciding. They had spent a month on the **schedule** and one evening on the marriage, which was, in the end, the correct proportion of the two.

中文翻译

决定是在家里一张温暖的桌边做出的。他妈妈请来了两家人，随后的辩论用她的话说既有很多乐趣又非常紧张。“他会告诉你们发生了什么，”她说，“我只说一点：婚姻的契约不是婚姻。”

会议的开头很正式。有人提出一项动议、一份把时间表增加三倍的请求，以及上首那一位的点头。“去申请这笔钱，”像父亲一样的叔父说，“必要时去求，但不要借。”像母亲一样的姑妈补充：“不要惊慌。抚养那个孩子的女人的担忧已经收到，而在家里，这份担忧很大。”

有一个极具表现力的瞬间：心爱的祖母借了一支笔，在文件上签了名，然后一拍放下，一秒钟里处置掉了三个月的怨恨。“新计划的香气胜过旧争吵的诅咒，”她说；而那位爱说话的堂兄，这一次什么也没说。

两个项目的分离早已悄悄开始。一个将继续；另一个会被移交一位能给它更多时间的接替者。“我知道，”林伟说，“我更喜欢小的那个。”他自己工时的陡降教会了他这一点，而外面骤降的气温让厨房感觉像一座港湾。

令人惊奇的是，决定是在没有人提高嗓门的情况下作出的。起雾的窗户、温热的盘子、人们还在那里的细小迹象：一切都表明这是一个已经做出了决定的家庭。“总要开始点什么，”堂兄最后说，“如果你愿意，给它起个花哨的名字；人还是那些人。”其中一部分是运气，另一部分是没有人计划过的部分：堂兄的沉默、姑妈的算计，以及一个家庭在不作决定的情况下作决定的方式。他们花了一个月安排日程，用一个晚上处理婚姻——说到底，这才是两者正确的比例。

Core Vocabulary · 核心词汇

Word / Pronunciation	Context meaning / source example
say sei POS: vt	vt. 说, 讲, 念, 说明, 指明; vi. 说, 讲; n. 意见, 发言权 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. the chance to speak; v. communicate or express nonverbally; v. utter aloud; v. state as one's opinion or judg...
like laik POS: a	a. 相似的, 同样的; vt. 喜欢, 愿意, 想; vi. 喜欢, 希望; n. 爱好, 同样的人(或物); prep. 象, 如同; adv. ... Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a similar kind; n. a kind of person; v. find enjoyable or agreeable; v. be fond of
happen 'hæpən POS: vi	vi. 发生, 发生, 恰巧 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: v. come to pass; v. happen, occur, or be the case in the course of events or by chance; v. chance to be or do s...
around ə'raʊnd POS: prep	prep. 包围, 在...周围, 四处; adv. 兜着圈子, 在附近, 到处 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: r. by a circular or circuitous route; r. in a circle or circular motion; r. to a particular destination either...
receive ri'si:v POS: vt	vt. 收到, 接到, 得到, 接待, 迎接, 承受; vi. 收到, 会客; [计] 接收 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: v. get something; come into possession of; v. receive a specified treatment (abstract); v. express willingness...
apply ə'plai POS: vt	vt. 涂, 应用; vi. 申请, 适用 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: v. be pertinent or relevant or applicable; v. ask (for something); v. refer (a word or name) to a person or thi...
concern kən'sɜ:n POS: n	n. 关心, 忧虑; vt. 与...有关, 使担心, 使挂念 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. something that interests you because it is important or affects you; n. an anxious feeling; n. a feeling of...
indicate 'ɪndikeɪt POS: vt	vt. 显示, 象征, 指示, 指出; [医] 指示 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: v. indicate a place, direction, person, or thing; either spatially or figuratively; v. to state or express bri...
wonder 'wʌndə POS: n	n. 奇迹, 惊奇, 惊愕; vt. 惊奇, 想知道; vi. 惊讶, 怀疑 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. the feeling aroused by something strange and surprising; n. something that causes feelings of wonder; v. hav...
debate di'beɪt POS: n	n. 辩论, 讨论; v. 争论, 辩论 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. the formal presentation of a stated proposition and the opposition to it (usually followed by a vote); v. a...
beginning bi'ɡɪnɪŋ POS: n	n. 开始 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. the event consisting of the start of something; n. the time at which something is supposed to begin; n. the...
warm wɜ:m POS: a	a. 暖和的, 暖的, 温暖的, 热烈的, 兴奋的, 激烈的, 多情的, 色情的; vt. 使温暖, 弄热, 使兴奋, 使充满仇恨; vi. ... Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: v. get warm or warmer; v. make warm or warmer; a. having or producing a comfortable and agreeable degree of hea...
invite in'vaɪt POS: vt	vt. 邀请, 请求, 引起, 招致; n. 邀请 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a colloquial expression for invitation; v. increase the likelihood of; v. invite someone to one's house; v. a...
nod nɒd POS: n	n. 点头, 打盹, 晃动; vi. 点头, 打盹; vt. 点头表示, 点(头) Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a sign of assent or salutation or command; n. the act of nodding the head; v. express or signify by nodding; ...
mom mʌm POS: n	n. 妈妈 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n informal terms for a mother
motion 'məʊʃən POS: n	n. 移动, 手势, 动作, 意向, 请求, 提议; v. 打手势 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a change of position that does not entail a change of location; n. a state of change; n. a formal proposal f...
request ri'kwest POS: n	n. 请求, 需要, 申请书; vt. 请求, 要求, 邀请; [计] 请求 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a formal message requesting something that is submitted to an authority; n. the verbal act of requesting; v. ...
fun fʌn POS: n	n. 乐趣, 玩笑, 娱乐; vi. 开玩笑; a. 供娱乐用的 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. activities that are enjoyable or amusing; n. verbal wit or mockery (often at another's expense but not to b...
schedule 'skedʒʊəl POS: n	n. 时间表, 一览表, 计划表, 议事日程; vt. 预定, 编制目录, 制...表, 安排 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. an ordered list of times at which things are planned to occur; v. plan for an activity or event; v. make a s...
luck lʌk POS: n	n. 运气, 幸运, 好运, 侥幸; vi. 靠好运成功 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. an unknown and unpredictable phenomenon that causes an event to result one way rather than another; n. an u...

Word / Pronunciation	Context meaning / source example
borrow 'bɒrəu POS: vt	vt. 借, 借入, 借用; vi. 借; [计] 借位; 借位数 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: v. get temporarily
replacement ri'pleismənt POS: n	n. 归还, 更换, 代替者; [医] 复位, 置换 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. the act of furnishing an equivalent person or thing in the place of another
divorce di'vɔ:s POS: n	n. 离婚; vt. 与...离婚 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. the legal dissolution of a marriage; v. get a divorce; formally terminate a marriage
beg beg POS: v	v. 乞求, 乞讨, 请求 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: v. call upon in supplication; entreat; v. ask to obtain free; v. dodge, avoid answering, or take for granted
panic 'pænik POS: n	n. 恐慌, 惊慌; a. 惊慌的, 没有理由的, 恐慌的; vt. 使惊慌, 使狂热; vi. 惊慌 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. an overwhelming feeling of fear and anxiety; n. sudden mass fear and anxiety over anticipated events; v. be...
steep sti:p POS: n	n. 浸渍, 悬崖; a. 险峻的, 陡峭的, 急剧升降的, 夸大的; v. 浸, 泡 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a steep place (as on a hill); v. devote (oneself) fully to; v. let sit in a liquid to extract a flavor or to...
fancy 'fænsi POS: n	n. 想象力, 幻想, 喜好; a. 想象的, 精美的, 新奇的, 奇特的, 高价的, 特级的; vt. 想象, 设想, 相信, 喜爱; vi. ... Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a kind of imagination that was held by Coleridge to be more casual and superficial than true imagination; v...
dispose dis'pəuz POS: vt	vt. 处理, 排列, 布置; vi. 处置 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: v. give, sell, or transfer to another; v. make receptive or willing towards an action or attitude or belief; v. ...
spite spait POS: n	n. 恶意, 怨恨, 使人烦恼的事物; vt. 故意刁难, 欺侮 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n feeling a need to see others suffer; n malevolence by virtue of being malicious or spiteful or nasty; v hurt...
commence kə'mens POS: v	v. (使)开始, 得学位 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: v take the first step or steps in carrying out an action; v set in motion, cause to start; v get off the ground
scent sent POS: n	n. 气味, 香味, 香水, 踪迹, 痕迹, 线索, 嗅觉; vt. 闻出, 嗅, 发觉, 使充满气味; vi. 嗅猎, 发出气味 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. an odor left in passing by which a person or animal can be traced; v. catch the scent of; get wind of
transmit træns'mit POS: vt	vt. 传输, 传染, 传达, 遗传, 发射, 传播; vi. 发射信号, 留传下来; [计] 传送 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: v. send from one person or place to another
plunge plʌndʒ POS: n	n. 钻进, 跳进, 跳水, 跳水池, 猛跌, 落下, 投入, 开始从事, 盲目投资; vi. 投入, 投身于, 跳进, 陷入, 下降; vt... Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a steep and rapid fall; v. dash violently or with great speed or impetuosity; v. begin with vigor; v. cause t...
beloved bi'lʌvd POS: a	a. 心爱的; n. 心爱的人 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a beloved person; used as terms of endearment; s. dearly loved
harbor 'hɑ:bə POS: n	n. 港, 避难所; v. 庇护, 藏匿, (使)入港停泊 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a place of refuge and comfort and security; v. maintain (a theory, thoughts, or feelings); v. secretly shelter...
curse kɜ:s POS: n	n. 咒骂, 诅咒; vt. 诅咒, 咒骂 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. profane or obscene expression usually of surprise or anger; n. a severe affliction; v. utter obscenities or...
tense tens POS: a	a. 紧张的, 拉紧的; v. (使)紧张, (使)拉紧; n. 时态 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a grammatical category of verbs used to express distinctions of time; v. increase the tension on; v. become...
marital 'mærɪtəl POS: a	a. 丈夫的, 婚姻的, 夫妇间的; [医] 婚姻的 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: a. of or relating to the state of marriage
triple 'tripl POS: n	n. 三倍数, 三个一组; a. 三倍的; vt. 使增至三倍; vi. 增至三倍 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a base hit at which the batter stops safely at third base; n. a quantity that is three times as great as an...
enhancement in'hɑ:nsmənt POS: n	n. 提高, 美化, 增进, 增强, 增加; [计] 增强, 加强, 提高, 充实 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. an improvement that makes something more agreeable
steamy 'sti:mi POS: a	a. 蒸汽的, 充满蒸汽的 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: s filled with steam or emitting moisture in the form of vapor or mist; s hot or warm and humid; s feeling great...

Word / Pronunciation	Context meaning / source example
talkative 'tɔ:kətɪv POS: a	a. 喜欢说话的, 饶舌的, 多嘴的 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: s full of trivial conversation; s unwisely talking too much; s friendly and open and willing to talk
motherly 'mʌðəli POS: a	a. 母亲的 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: s. befitting a mother; warm and nurturing
fatherly 'fɑ:ðəli POS: a	a. 父亲的, 如父亲的, 慈爱的 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: s. like or befitting a father or fatherhood; kind and protective
demonstrative dɪ'mɒnstrətɪv POS: a	a. 说明的, 指示的 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: a. given to or marked by the open expression of emotion; s. serving to demonstrate